

THE MIRAGE OF ADVANCEMENT

AI AND THE FACADE OF CONSCIENCE IN GAMING

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A

h, the golden era. A time when video games were straightforward, and their characters as

reliable as clockwork. But now, they assure me, the tides have turned. They proclaim that artificial intelligence (AI) is transforming the gaming landscape, bestowing non-player characters (NPCs) with a ghost of conscience and generating content spontaneously. Allow me to share my thoughts on this so-called 'advancement'.

In the good old times, NPCs possessed a unique allure in their predictability. You were certain that the blacksmith would always be hammering away at his anvil, the innkeeper would always have a cozy room ready, and the antagonist would always be lurking in the depths of the dungeon. There was a soothing rhythm to it, a sense of harmony. But now, with AI, all that is being tossed aside. They claim that these AI-empowered NPCs can respond to player actions in real-time, that they can learn and adapt. But I question, what's the purpose? All it does is introduce a layer of unpredictability to the game. And let's not forget, these NPCs aren't genuinely conscious. They're merely following a series of intricate algorithms designed to imitate human behavior. It's all a grand spectacle, a cheap trick of consciousness.

And then there's the issue of AI-generated content. Procedurally gener-



ated universes, they label it. Endless possibilities, they assert. But what's the worth of a world that hasn't been meticulously shaped by human hands? These AI-generated universes lack the touch of a human designer, the painstaking attention to detail that makes a game world truly captivating. In the end, all this AI does is create a facade of complexity and depth. But scratch beneath the surface, and you'll discover that it's all empty. The NPCs may appear more 'real', the worlds may seem more 'expansive', but it's all just a mirage. This is a stark contrast from the golden era when games were uncomplicated, and you knew precisely what you were signing up for.

So, let them have their AI and their facade-conscious NPCs. I, for one, will stick to the classics. Games that were constructed with passion and care, not algorithms and machine learning. Games that prioritise the player's

experience over technological gimmicks. Because when the sun sets, that's what truly counts. Now, don't misunderstand me. I'm not opposed to progress. I'm not against the concept of utilising technology to enrich our experiences. But when that technology begins to supplant the human touch, the creativity and imagination that goes into crafting a game, that's where I draw the line.

You see, video games are a form of art. They're a platform for storytelling, for creating immersive worlds where players can lose themselves. And while AI can undoubtedly assist in creating these worlds, it should never supplant the human element. The charm of a game lies not in its complexity, but in its simplicity. In the way it can stir emotions, narrate a story, and create a sense of immersion. And no amount of AI can duplicate that.

So, the next time you pick up a controller, remember this. Remember the golden era when games were uncomplicated when NPCs were reliable, and when the worlds were handcrafted with love and care. And ask yourself, is this advancement truly worth it? Because in the end, it's not about how sophisticated the technology is. It's about the experience. The joy of playing a game, of losing yourself in another realm. And that, my friends, is something that no AI can ever truly duplicate. **d**